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Author(s): Syed Ali Nadeem Rezavi

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MERCANTILE LIFE IN MUGHAL INDIA

Syed Ali Nadeem Rezavi

The merchant class in the Mughal Empire can, for convenience of investigation, be categorized into three distinct groups, viz., (1) the big merchants and ship owners (*mahâjans* and *sâhs*), (2) the smaller and medium commodity merchants or traders (*baniyas*) who frequented the local markets and (3) the petty shopkeepers and hawkers.

Comprising both Hindus and Muslims, this class appears to have been largely dominated by the Hindu and Jain merchants who were collectively known as *baniyas*,¹ the designation not only representing their caste, but also their profession. The predominance of the *baniyas* in the medieval society is succinctly brought out in one of the verses of Kabir (c.1510) wherein he sees God as a *baniya*:

My Lord is a *baniya*. He conducts his commerce so easily. Without scales and balances, He weighs the entire Universe.²

These *baniyas*, largely belonged to the *vaishya* caste. This gave them a distinct social status. While describing the four principal castes, Tavernier says:

The third caste is that of the Baniyans, who attach themselves to trade, some being Shroffs, i.e., money changers or bankers and others brokers, by whose agency the merchants buy and sell...³

The term *baniya* has its origins in the Sanskrit word '*vâñij*' which means a merchant. In Mughal terminology the word used for the *baniya* is *baqqâl*.⁴ Thus describing the origin of the *baniyas*, Abul Fazl writes:

One caste of the *Bais* [Vaishyas], which is designated *Bânik*, is called *baniya* in ordinary usage and *baqqal* in Arabic....⁵

According to an 18th Century lexicographical work, the Arabic term *baqqâl* meant a *baniya* or 'grain merchant' in India but a 'green grocer' in Iran.⁶ Generally speaking the term *baniya*, at least from the 17th Century was an inclusive term incorporating within its ambit all those who cared to be so labelled.⁷ By an extension of usage, to the European merchants of the 18th Century, the term '*banian*' denoted all natives who served them as agents or brokers.

It appears that the *baniyas* mainly pursued the business of money-lending and banking, and traded in commodities like grain, *ghee* (clarified butter), spices, jewellery, clothing and grocery.⁸ However, they avoided doing commerce in 'polluting substances'.⁹ On the other

hand, a *baniya* would also manage the household of his master which included engaging and dismissing servants, paying his bills besides sometimes lending him money.¹⁰

It appears that trade of almost every kind had been the occupation of the *baniyas*, and as compared to any other caste, they have remained loyal to their traditional occupation. As late as 1911 in Central Provinces, 60 percent of the *baniyas* were found to be engaged in trade, whereas only 19 percent of the Brahmins had any religious occupation.¹¹

This mercantile class consisted of entrepreneurial sub-castes linked together through a system of organised markets.¹² Thus instead of designating the *baniya* as an occupational term, Russell applied it to caste which had within its folds various sub-castes.¹³

Abul Fazl mentions forty-eight sub-castes of the *baniyas*.¹⁴ This figure finds support from Ali Muhammad Khan who goes on to give the names of as many as eighty four sub-castes of the *baniyas*.¹⁵ Ovington on the other hand mentions that there were only twenty four sub-castes of the *baniyas*.¹⁶ It will be seen that all these figures are largely convention, since they are 24 or multiples thereof.

We are also informed that these sub-castes were “mostly named after places, villages and settlements”.¹⁷ Further, it appears that they transcended religious affiliations and included both Hindus and Jains. We have the testimony of the author of *Dabistân-i Mazâhib* who says that “many of the *baniyas* and *bohras* belonged to this (Jain) community” who were into the business of selling grain, while some “lived by service”.¹⁸ While enumerating the sub-castes of the *baqqâls* (*baniyas*), Ali Muhammad Khan mentions the “*Saravag baqqâls*” and others, who were Jains, and the *Maishri baqqâls* who were Vaishnavites, both of whom were sub-divided into eighty four sub-castes respectively.¹⁹ As late as the late 18th Century, we have the testimony of Malcolm that the Jains dominated the *baniya* community at least in the Malwa region:

The Soucars (*sâhûkârs*), Shroffs (*sarrâfs*) and Bunnians (*baniyas*) in Malwa are either of the Jain or Vishnu faith, but by far the greatest numbers are the former, and their prevailing influence and wealth attracts many converts. Almost all the Vaisya and Sudra agents and servants they employ, if not before Jains, conform to the tenets of that sect.²⁰

It is also interesting to note, as Irfan Habib points out, that the sub-castes of the *baniyas* were defined by endogamy and restrictions on dining with members of different sub-castes.²¹ We have the testimony

of Ovington that these sub-castes refrained 'from an indiscriminate mixture in marriages, and from eating together in common'.²²

As far as the non-Hindu merchant communities in Medieval India are concerned, we have numerous references to Armenians as well as Muslim merchants. According to Manucci, the Pathans, although for a greater part they served as soldiers, also pursued commerce. He even says that they resorted 'to no other occupation' than these two.²³ Being 'avaricious of nature', he explains, 'they put by money and grow into merchants'.²⁴ In spite of the fact that Manucci is very specific when he says that in Gujarat 'all these merchants are Hindu by religion',²⁵ there is much information regarding the activities of Muslim merchants in Gujarat, especially at Ahmadabad, Surat and Cambay.²⁶ Fryer, while mentioning the Muslim merchants comments on their extravagant and ostentatious style of living as compared to the frugal attitude of the Hindu *baniyas*. He further mentions that these Muslim merchants were "buoy'd up more by the Authority of their Religion and Cast, than Cunning, the *Banyan* being forced to flee to them for patronage..."²⁷

This mercantile class which controlled the commerce in Mughal India were the natural link between the producers and consumers.²⁸

Depending on their professional specialization, the merchant class comprising the small and medium traders in the Mughal Empire can be further divided into three distinct categories, viz. (1) the brokers, (2) money-lenders or money-changers and (3) the commodity merchants.

The brokers were the 'middle men' who directed "the purchaser to the merchandise and the seller to the price".²⁹ To these brokers the term *dallâl* was generally applied. Sometimes even the European factors and travellers have used this term to connote the brokers.³⁰ The *dallâls* who exclusively dealt in animals, especially horses, were known as *jallâb*.³¹

From *A'in-i Akbari* it appears that a *dallâl* was appointed in each quarter (*muhal্লা*) of the town to supervise the selling and buying in the local market.³² No transaction could take place without his knowledge.³³ It also appears that the Mughal government appointed a 'town broker' for market transactions.³⁴ It further seems that these *dallâls* were also an essential part of the commercial establishments of the foreign merchants, who depended on their services for their business transactions. Thus Ovington writing in early 1690's says:

For the Buying and more advantageous disposing of the Company's goods, there are Brokers appointed, who are of the Bannian Caste, skilled in the Rates and value of all the commodities in India.³⁵

These “idolator” (i.e. non-Muslim Hindu and Jain) *baniyas* were universally preferred as *dallâls* by the European factors as well as the Mughal nobles. Tavernier advises his compatriots to select a broker “who should be a native of the country, an idolator and not a Musalman, because all the workmen with whom he will have to do are idolators”.³⁶ Thevenot too states that “everyone hath his Baniyan in the Indies” as a broker. He also states that some of these brokers grew into the richest merchants in India.³⁷ We have the testimony of Pelsaert that the ‘Hindu’ *baniyas* also acted as brokers to all the Muslim merchants as well.³⁸

The reasons for preferring the *baniyas* as *dallâls* are not far to seek. Writing in 1674 Fryer explains that these *baniya dallâls* were:

...expert in all the studied arts of Thriving and Insinuation; so that, Lying, Dissembling, Cheating, are their Masterpiece: Their whole desire is to have Money pass through their fingers, to which a great part is sure to stick: For they well understand the constant turning of Cash amounts both to the Credit and Profit of him that is so occupied; which these *Banyans* are sensible of, otherwise they would not be so industrious to enslave themselves.³⁹

The importance of the brokers in the trade in Mughal India is succinctly brought out by the account of Caesar Fredericke, the Merchant of Venice, who was at Cambay in 1563. He speaks of the ‘Brokers which are Gentiles’ who are men of ‘great authority’ having under them fifteen or twenty servants. Whenever a fleet of small ships entered the port of Cambay, the brokers assembled on the waterfront and the merchants embarking from the ship handed over their goods to one of them.⁴⁰ The appointed broker after receiving the cargo, commanded his servants to carry the goods on carts to town where, Fredericke says:

...the Brokers have divers empty houses meet [proper] for the lodging of Marchants, furnished onely with bedsteds, tables, chaires and empty jarres for water: then the Broker sayth to the Marchant, Goe and repose your selfe and take rest in the city...⁴¹

The broker cleared the merchants’ cargo and after paying the requisite customs duly transported it to the merchant’s lodging. If the merchant concerned then wished to sell off his goods, the broker did so immediately.⁴² The stranglehold of the broker over the merchant was however such that:

...and when as the Marchant thinketh that he cannot sell his goods at the price curreant, he may tary as long as he will, but they cannot be solde by any man but by that Broker that hath taken them on land and payed the custome...⁴³

According to Tavernier it was the 'custom throughout Asia that nothing is sold except in the presence of a broker, and each class of goods has its own separate one'.⁴⁴ Almost a similar impression regarding the monopolistic attitude of the *baniyas* and brokers is created by Fryer. He remarks:

... such is their policy that without these, neither you nor the Natives themselves shall do any Business, though they are worse Brokers than Jews...⁴⁵

Fryer equates the *baniyas* with pests and complains:

To this place belong two sorts of Vermin, the Fleas and *Banyans*: the one harbouring in the Sand... The other Vermin are the *Banyans* themselves, that hang like Horse-leeches, till they have suck'd both *sanguinem & succum* (I mean money) from you: As soon as you have set your Foot on Shore, they crowd in their service, interposing between you and all Civil Respect, as if you had no other Business but to be gull'd; so that unless you have some to make your way through them, they will interrupt your going, and never leave till they have drawn out something for their advantage...⁴⁶

The foreign merchants' dependence on the brokers was probably partly due to language constraints. Thus Fryer in 1674-75 writes on the deceitful means of the brokers at Surat:

It would be too mean to descend to indirect ways, which are chiefly managed by the *Banyans*, the fittest Tools for any deceitful Undertaking; out of whom are made Broakers for the Company, and Private Persons, who are allowed Two per cent on all Bargains, besides what they squeeze secretly out of the price of things bought; which cannot be well understood for want of knowledge in their language; which Ignorance is safer, than to hazard being poisoned for prying too nearly into their Actions: Though the Company, to encourage Young men in their Service, maintain a Master to learn them to Write and Read the Language, and an annuity to be annexed when they gain perfection therein, which few attempt, and fewer attain.⁴⁷

Generally it appears that in spite of all the negative aspersions and fraudulent practices attributed to them, these brokers were quite faithful to the merchants whom they served. Thus we have the testimony of Benjamin Robinson at Surat who wrote to the Company on 26th December 1638 that "commonly when they are solely entrusted with such a busines [of buying and supplying merchandise of good quality] they are not unfaithfull".⁴⁸ In case of a fraud they were liable to be punished. However, in the punishment care was to be taken not to be too harsh to frighten them away or gain their enmity. Thus president of the English Company at Surat, Methwold, advised the factors at

Ahmadabad in 1638:

...only take care that you fall not too heavy upon their persons in corporall punishment, we meane chawbucking [*châbuk*, a whip, i.e., whipping] them, least, being guilty and in that respect desperate persons, they may consent to loose themselves that you may find trouble; in which particular wee doe rather approve that you should deliver them over unto the Mahumetan power; but therein also wee would not have you to bee too forward, since wee know that nothing will bee taken from them in that way which will bee returned for our satisfaction...⁴⁹

It is interesting to note that this advice for moderation in punishment of a broker caught in fraudulent practice is followed by a censure of the factors at Ahmadabad who apparently did not heed the advice and imprisoned the errant broker for three days 'without rice or water'.⁵⁰

The brokers in the European companies during the 17th Century were entitled to anything ranging from 1% to 3% of the total transaction. Thus in 1636 we hear of a broker being paid 1% for his endeavours at Baroda.⁵¹ According to Fryer, in 1670's the brokers were "allowed Two percent on all Bargains, besides what they squeeze secretly out of the price of things bought."⁵² Besides the commission (*dastûr*), the *dallâls* would also make further demands on the European factors under whom they served. Streynsham Master tells us that in December 1679 Hari Charan, the 'house Baniyan' at Balasore demanded Rs.25/- per mensem as wages besides the 'dustoor' of 'one anna upon Rs. 100/- , that is Rs.1-9 annas per cent'. This broker was finally allowed "2/3 parts" of the claimed *dastur*.⁵³ In 1690's the share of brokers appear to have risen to 3% of the total transaction.⁵⁴ In larger transactions the earnings of the brokers, however could go as high as 10 to 10½ per cent.⁵⁵

Like the *dallâls*, the profession of the *sarrâfs* (money-changers / bankers) was also mostly held by the *baniyas*. The omnipresence of this specialized class is also commented upon by our sources. To quote Tavernier:

In India a village must be very small indeed if it has not a money-changer, called a Shroff, who acts as a banker to make remittances of money and issue letters of exchange.⁵⁶

No payment could be made or received unless the *sarrâf* was shown the money to assess its purity. Essentially, the work of the *sarrâf* was to test and change money. A coin had to be expertly examined for its genuineness or metallic purity, age and weight.⁵⁷ The reason was that a silver coin by wear and tear could lose some weight and consequently become lighter.⁵⁸ Thus if an amount was deposited with a *sarrâf* in

new silver coin but payment was made in old coin, high profit was earned by the *sarrâf* due to difference in the weight of old and new silver coins.⁵⁹ The *sarrâfs* also earned much profit from assaying gold and silver. For his labour he would receive a 'commission of $1/16^{\text{th}}$ of a rupee per cent'.⁶⁰

The parsimonious nature of the *sarrâfs*, and their practice of collecting even the gold-dust from their assays is commented upon by Tavernier:

...of all the gold which remains on the touchstone after an assay has been made, and of which were here make no account, far from so small a think to be lost, they collect it with the aid of a ball, made half of black pitch, and half of wax, with which they rub the stone which carries the gold, and at the end of some years they burn the ball and so obtain the gold which it had accumulated. The ball is about the size of our tennis-court balls, and the stone is like those which our goldsmiths commonly use.⁶¹

Commenting on the expertise of the *sarrâfs*, Tavernier at one place comments:

All the Jews who occupy themselves with money and exchange in the empire of the Grand Seigneur pass for being very sharp, but in India they would scarcely be apprentices to these changers...⁶²

This comment of Tavernier finds support from an incident reported by Banarsi Das in his autobiography, *Ardhakathanak*, which incidentally also contains much information regarding the *sarrâfs* and the commodity merchants in the Mughal Empire.⁶³ Banarsi Das was himself a jeweller and commodity merchant who saw the reigns of Akbar, Jahangir and Shahjahan. During his journey from Jaunpur to Agra in 1616 he was accompanied by a moneylender of the Maheshwari clan and two Brahmins of Mathura. When the party arrived at a place identified as Korara near Ghatampur, they halted in a local *sarai*. The two Brahmins, we are informed, visited the house of an Ahir prostitute. One of the said Brahmins went to a 'silver merchant's shop' (*hâr*) and exchanged a rupee for small coins of which he bought plenty of food and confectioner's delicacies (*sâf*) for the woman. The next day the *sarrâf* with whom the Brahmin had exchanged his rupee came and charged him of having given him counterfeit money (*gaisâl hai badli dai*). The Brahmin denied the charge. In the ensuing tussle the money changer took twenty five more rupees from the folds of the Brahmins *dhoti* all the while claiming that all this money was counterfeit. Banarsi Das then says that it was a trick applied by the *sarrâf* to extort money: feigning to go to the *kotwâl* with the counterfeit currency, the merchant went to his own house and changed it. It was after much trouble and

some luck that the Brahmin and others could escape from the clutches of the local officials.⁶⁴

In the towns, the *baniyas* could also be found hawking cloth, cowries, and even salt. Ovington describes how near the marketplace at Surat “tis not very easie to pass through the multitude of *Bannians* and other Merchants that expose their Goods. For here they stand with their Silks and Stuffs in their Hands, or upon their Heads, to invite such as pass by to come and buy them.”⁶⁵ More characteristic, however, was the *baniya* shopkeeper, commonly selling rice and ghee (Indian butter) to a poor clientele, who often had to ask for credit and expected harsh conditions in return.⁶⁶ Such shops in a large city like Delhi vastly outnumbered shops selling the finer commodities, though Banyas must have been prominent in keeping shops of the latter kind as well. Bemier (1663) speaks of shops at Delhi “where nothing is seen but pots of oil or butter, piles of baskets filled with rice, barley, chick-peas, wheat and an endless variety of other grain and pulse.” These outnumbered the shops selling fine cloth and silk and other fine stuffs by twenty-five to one.⁶⁷ *Ardhakathanaka* gives many instances of the merchants’ shops in various cities like Jaunpur, Fatehpur and Agra. In 1576, Kharagsen is said to have opened a shop (*hât*) in Jaunpur.⁶⁸ Similarly during one of his trips to Agra, Banarsi Das took his merchandise to the *hât* (shop or was it a firm?) of his father-in-law situated in Katla (Katra) Parvez.⁶⁹ At another occasion he mentions a business warehouse (*kothi*) where he left behind his merchandise comprising of bales of cloth, oil and *ghee* before proceeding to his brother-in-law’s house in Agra, which he says was situated in ‘*katla Moti*’ (Katra Moti).⁷⁰ Apart from the *Katra* (an enclosed market), Banarsi Das also mentions the whole-sale markets (*mandi*) and the cattle market (*nakhhâs*).⁷¹ These markets were held twice a day, early in the morning and ‘a little before’ sunset.⁷²

Shopkeepers are naturally to be distinguished from merchants proper. They were the pedlars who would carry on their business on a petty scale.⁷³ Pelsaert, although labelling them ‘nominally free’, compares their status to workmen, peons and servants. He says that their status differed very little from ‘voluntary slavery’.⁷⁴ He further mentions:

Whatever he [the shopkeeper] may deal in – spices, drugs, fruit, cotton goods, cloth, or anything else – the shopkeeper is held in greater respect than than the workman, and some of them are even well-to-do; but they must not let the fact be seen, or they will be the victims of a trumped-up charge, and whatever they have will be confiscated in legal form, because informers swarm like flies round

the governors, and make no difference between friends and enemies, perjuring themselves when necessary in order to remain in favour. Further, they are subject to a rule that if the King's nobles, or governors, should require any of their goods, they must sell for very little – less than half price; for to begin with, they must give great weight for small coins, the difference being 20 per cent; then 9 per cent is deducted for *dastûri* [commission]; then clerks, overseers, cashiers and others all know very well how to get their share; so that in such circumstances the unfortunate shopkeeper may be robbed in a single hour of the profits of a whole month, although they bear the general cost.⁷⁵

The contention of Pelsaert regarding the plight of the shopkeepers is highlighted by Manucci in the case of large suppliers as well. He mentions the case of a grocer who supplied herbs and vegetables to the household of Jafar Khan during the latter's journey to Kashmir. The grocer submitted the account of the supplied goods to the treasurer of the Khan who allegedly found the amount 'enormous' and deducted a sum of "eighty thousand rupees" (!) from the total amount due. It was only when the grocer appealed directly to the Nawab that he was able to get his money released.⁷⁶ The shopkeepers appear to have been further afflicted by the marauding thieves who infested the markets. Thus Manucci mentions that in Goa the shopkeepers selling commodities like garlic, pepper, butter were not only constrained to close shop around sunset but also put up cages around their shops so that they or their goods may not be directly exposed to thieves.⁷⁷

The expertise of the *baniyas*, appear to have been a result of the early training and education. This is reflected in their outlook towards education of their children. Not much emphasis was put on formal education; instead practical training was preferred. In fact, the attitude of the entire community towards excessive academic pursuits was something bordering on scorn: Banarasidas, a Jain merchant, was advised by his elders:

Pay attention to what the old and the experienced have to say...Give up your foolish pursuit of learning. Too much learning is for a Brahman (*bâman*) and *Bhât* (bard). The son of a *baniya* should sit at the shop (*hât*). Those who are too studious have to beg (*bahut padhai so mângai bhîk*). Remember son this saying of the elders.⁷⁸

Thus the main emphasis amongst the members of this class was on training in business techniques, arithmetic and accountancy which was imparted from childhood. These were the pillars of their business management.⁷⁹ Tavernier informing us of this attitude remarks:

...they accustom their children at an early age to shun slothfulness,

and instead of letting them go into the streets to loose their time at play, as we generally allow ours teach them arithmetic, which they learn perfectly, using for it neither pen nor counters, but the memory alone, so that in a moment they will do a sum, however difficult it may be. They are always with their fathers, who instruct them in trade, and do nothing without at the same time explaining it to them...⁸⁰

Roques, too, echoes the same view when he writes:

...They work hard at arithmetic and are very good at calculation. It is their only patrimony from home, for the father gives nothing to his son...⁸¹

Similar is the statement of Ovington who also writes that:

...the Bannian, by the strength of his brain only, will sum up his accounts with equal exactness, and quicker dispatch, than the readiest arithmetician can with his pen.⁸²

Banarsi Das's father, Kharagsen was sent to school (*chatsâl / chaksâl*) at the age of eight where he learned to read and write. He also acquired the art of testing precious metals such as gold and silver for impurities (*parkhai rajat taka sovann*). He soon became skilful in distinguishing good coins from the bad and proficient in preparing accounts for the family business of money lending, properly noting all the details of a transaction (*lena dena bidhisau likhai*) and began to frequent the market-place regularly and was soon initiated into the trade of money-lending (*baithey hât sarâfi sikhai*). This training continued for a period of four years (i.e. till the age of twelve).⁸³

Banarsi Das himself joined school at the age of eight. He says he was sent to a school run by a Brahmin pedagogue. Within a year he says he became proficient in reading and writing and 'more schooling was not needed'.⁸⁴

We do not know what apart from account keeping might have been taught at such *chatsâls* (preparatory schools) in which the children of these *baniya* class were admitted. But Banarsi Das's grandfather Muldas was well educated having studied both Hindi and Persian (*hindugî- pârsi*) and he might well have been taught some Persian at the school.⁸⁵ Banarsi Das himself through out his autobiography uses a number of Persian terms which he might have picked up during his one year sojourn in school.

Tavernier in a long passage deals with the training imparted to the children of the diamond merchants whom he encountered in the mines at Rammalakota near Bijapur:

It is very pleasant to see the young children of these merchants and

other people of the country, from the age of ten years up to the age of fifteen or sixteen, assemble every morning under a tree which is in the town square. Each has his diamond weights in a little bag suspended on one side, and on the other a purse attached to his waistband, which contains as much as 500 or 600 gold pagodas. They seat themselves there awaiting the arrival of anyone who wishes to sell diamonds, either brought from this or some other mine. When anyone brings a stone he places it in the hands of the *eldest of the children, who is, so to speak, the chief of the band*; he looks at it and passes it on him who sits next. Thus it goes hand to hand till it returns to the first one without anyone saying a word.

He then asks the price of the specimen, wishing to purchase, if possible; and if by chance he buys at too high a price he is responsible. In the evening these children count up what they have purchased, and after examining the stones separate them according to their water, weight, and cleanliness. Next they price each as they expect to dispose of them to strangers, and by this they see how far the value exceeds the cost of purchase. They then carry them to the great merchants who always have a number of parcels to match, and *all the profit is divided among the children, save only that their chief receives a quarter per cent more than the others*. Young as they are, they know the value of all the stones so well that if one of them has bought a stone and is willing to lose a half per cent, another gives him cash for it. You can seldom show them a parcel of a dozen stones, among which they will not discover four or five with some flaw, point, or defect at the angles.⁸⁶

Thus in the case of Banarsi Das as well we find that soon on completing school in 1595, at the age of nine years he became a small merchant, by selling cowry-shells and earning some money (*kori bech banij tin gahyo*).⁸⁷ When he presented his first earnings to his grand mother, he says that she performed the ritual of thanksgiving by felicitating the family deity Sati Aut and distributed sweetmeats.⁸⁸

The *Baniya* usually appears as an individual merchant, broker, or banker, but the family (the Hindu joint family of modern law) often acted as a firm, with joint investments and profits. Tavernier, speaking of the brokers, gives a lively description of the family firm:

These brokers are commonly, as it were, chiefs of their families, for whom they hold all the joint property in trust to turn it to account. For that reason those qualified by years and experience are selected so that they may be able to secure benefit to all the kinsmen, being both the depositories and guardians of their goods. Every evening, when they return from business... the oldest of the kinsmen assemble at the house of the broker, who renders an account of what he has done during the day, and they hold counsel together as to what should be done in the future. He is especially exhorted to take care of their

business, and if possible to defraud rather than be defrauded.⁸⁹

When in 1556 Muldas, the grandfather of Banarsi Das died, Kharagsen (the father of Banarsi Das) along with his mother found shelter with one of his senior relatives, Madan Singh Srimal, a jeweller at Jaunpur. It was he who now looked after the business interests of the family.⁹⁰

Partnerships (*shirkat*) within the family could also be formed to carry on business. Thus we have the example of Khargsen entering into a business partnership with his paternal uncle Sundar Das who was a *sarrâf* dealing with gold.⁹¹ Kharagsen also invested some money in this family partnership.⁹² The partnership appears to have been fruitful for it was during the years of this partnership that Kharagsen not only got married but also bought a house.⁹³ When the partnership finally ended after the death of Sundar Das, the dissolution of the partnership could easily be settled between Kharagsen and the heirs of Sundar Das on the basis of 'written accounts'.⁹⁴

Partnerships were also formed outside the kinship circles. Thus we have the reference to Kharagsen entering into a partnership with Ramdas a *baniya* belonging to the Agarwal sub-caste.⁹⁵ Similarly Banarsi Das entered into a partnership (*sirkao*) twice, once with Dharamdas, a member of the Oswal clan of Delhi. This partnership continued for almost two years.⁹⁶ The terms of this partnership founded in 1611 are described in some detail. Dharamdas, an Oswal, was put in partnership with Banarasidas by his father and uncle, who were rich dealers in jewels (a family firm?). They advanced the partners Rs. 500 as capital (*punji*). The two partners used it to go around Agra and buy and sell jewels, keeping a daily accounts book (*likhi rojnama khatiai*).⁹⁷ After two years, Banarasidas wished to end the partnership. All the goods held under the partnership were then sold, and the capital of Rs. 500 was returned to Dharamdas's father. Banarasidas had hoped to make a profit had the goods fetched more than this sum; but that was not to be. When in 1616 he terminated his partnership with Narottamdas at Jaunpur, all the assets were divided (equally?) between the two partners, the statement of settlement being made in two copies, one to be kept by each.⁹⁸

There were instances also of collaboration between the *baniya* merchants and the Muslim merchants. The Hindu and Muslim merchants of Surat not only did business with one another, but jointly owned cargo as well as cargo-loading boats. In 1643, when the imperial ship *Ganjawar* was being loaded to sail for Jedda, it carried the cargo of both Hindu and Muslim merchants, as is shown by documents of 1643 contained in an early 18th Century diary:

Dastak to Upari [officer] of Ganjawar, 1643

"One *jaliha* of Abdul Wahab and Manikji according to the regulation of Malikh(?) has been dispatched for (loading) aboard the auspicious ship. Let it be accepted (and loaded). Dated 24 Ziqad, 1052 [= 13 Feb. 1643]."⁹⁹

Dustak to Upari of the ship Ganjawar, 1643

"One *tauri* with cargo belonging to Hari Dar, Donki, Haniya, Dabash, Aziz Beg and Mulla Jalal has been loaded and dispatched. It should be checked with record and loaded aboard the ship. Dated Zilhij, 1052, R.Y. 16 [= March 1643]."¹⁰⁰

In December 1722 Ahmad Chalebi, Abdu'r Rahman, and other merchants laid a charter of demands before Momin Khan, the Customer (*Mutasaddi*) of Surat on behalf of "the *mahajans* [Hindu bankers] and the people of the Port of Surat." Wherever these concerned specific individuals, these were invariably non-Muslims: Shahpur Parsi, seller of *ilacha-cloth*; Manikchand and Shahar (?) *baqqâls* [Banyas]. In other grievances too the *mahâjans* and *sâhûkars* are specifically mentioned as those aggrieved. In July 1726 "Mulla Muhammad, and Ahmad Chalebi and other merchants" of Surat again banded together to represent the grievances of "cloth merchants and *biyupâris*" among others, to the Castellan of Surat. When the nephew of the Castellan gave a reception to leading merchants to confirm reconciliation, the list of guests included nine named Muslims and five Hindus. A number of merchants invited remain un-named.¹⁰¹

Thus we find that there was some sort of a bond of solidarity among the *baniya* class. It was this which resulted in joint actions by the members of this community. In 1616 at Surat the entire community closed shop and threatened to leave the city:

...through some violence done by him to a chiefe Bannyane, the whole multitude assembled, shutt up their shoppes, and (as their custome), after a generall complaint to the Governor lefte the cittie, pretendeing to goe to the courte for justice.¹⁰²

Yet again in 1666 we find such 'joint action' which resulted out of a dispute with a *qâzi*:

...the Bannians having bound themselves under severe penalties not to open any of their shops without orders from their Mahager [*mahâjan*] or Generall Councill, there was not any provisions to be got; the tanksall (mint) and customshouse shut; no money to be procured...¹⁰³

This rudimentary consciousness of having same interests as a member of a 'class' however do not appear to rest on a firm ground. The very

specialized profession of *Sarrafs* led to a separation between them and other *baniya* merchants. When in the 1650s the English had a dispute with the *sarrafs* of Surat over the payment of insurance on the ship *Supply*, a committee of "four Banyans" (apparently, *baniya* merchants) appointed by the governor supported the English case, but the *sarrafs* refused to accept their decision.¹⁰⁴ A sharper cleavage occurred in 1715 at Ahmadabad, where matters came nearly to an armed conflict between the merchants led by *the nagarseeth* ("town merchant") Kapur Chand Bhansali: and the *sarrafs* led by Hari Ram, factor to Madan Gopal, the head of the *sarrâfs* (then at Delhi), over the issue of an increase in a deduction called *ânth* that was made when cashing bills.¹⁰⁵ We thus have an example where divergent professional interests could divide the Banya caste vertically.

Acquisition of profit was the keystone of a *baniya's* mercantile pursuits. To achieve this, he did not hesitate to manipulate things howsoever unethical it might seem. It was this reason that led *baniyas* to create artificial scarcities by hoarding commodities. Muhnta Nainsi records an interesting incident about the *baniyas* of Gujarat. A large amount of hoarded grain had no demand in the market due to successive bumper harvests in Gujarat. This resulted in a great loss (*tote*) to the merchants. They ultimately took the help of magicians (*vartiya*) through whose efforts there were no rains the entire year in 4000 villages of Kelakot. This helped the merchants in selling out their entire hoarded stock. The rains further failed for three or four years. Obviously, this multiplied their profits.¹⁰⁶

Hoarding of grain by the members of the *baniya* class for profit seems to have been a universal phenomenon.¹⁰⁷ A Jain traveller, who was a saint, writes that in 1691 when there was a bumper harvest, the *baniyas* hoarded grain in the *kothis* (grain silos) and underground stores.¹⁰⁸ The *baniyas* later sold the stored grain at higher prices. Next year, in 1692, the merchants purchased grain at lower rates and stored it, but unfortunately it was destroyed due to excessive rains. This did not dishearten them: they brought grain from the Deccan to earn profit.¹⁰⁹

Indeed persistence was a characteristic of the *baniya* culture. In 1633 when the entire population of the town of Sarang near Broach fled away because of severe famine, the *baniyas* stayed there to sell grain to travellers.¹¹⁰

Roques who is a severe critic of the *baniyas* and their ways, gives us a contrary picture:

They are in continuous perplexity, in fear of losing their investment,

because they handle the biggest business. They are so sensitive to loss that they are inconsolable at the least reverse of fortune, however modest that might be. As their soul is low and grovelling, the desire of profit touches them so close and with so much avidity that they are not preoccupied with others.¹¹¹

In order to fortify themselves against possible loss, they habitually deceived the customers by passing on goods of poor quality at higher prices in contravention of their contract.¹¹²

Since trade required capital, great care was taken to save money. This habit of saving was characteristic of the *baniyas*. Roques observes:

When by dint of work or intrigue they would have saved up to one rupee... they would bury it, and would never bring it out, for whatever need it might be, and would rather die than touch it.¹¹³

The *baniya's* most favourable form of savings were ornaments of gold and silver. This seems to have served a dual purpose: for the women of the family ornaments were indicators of social status; and secondly, these ornaments insured them in times of emergency.¹¹⁴

The attitude of the father of Banarasidas towards hoarding or saving is an indicator of its wider acceptance as a norm of the *baniya* life. Banarsi Das' father, Kharagsen spent money on the wedding of his elder daughter out of "underground hoarded wealth" (*sampati gadi*).¹¹⁵

This habit of saving and amassing wealth appears to have been practiced even by the wealthiest *baniyas*. To quote Ovington:

They [*baniyas*] are mainly addicted to prosecute their temporal interest and the amassing of treasure; and therefore will fly at the securing of a pice, though they can command whole lakhs of rupees. I know those among them computed to be worth an hundred thousand pounds... For they are always upon the thoughts of increasing their wealth.¹¹⁶

Frugality seems to have been an essential part of a *baniya's* life. Roques observes:

This they openly show in their manner of living which is so mean that the most miserable petty thieves put them to shame if these two were compared. It is useless to go into details as to whether they are more thrifty in everything necessary for life or only in what can distinguish the wealth of the ones from its lack with regard to others. Everything is the same among them; the rich do not spend more than the poor...¹¹⁷

But this value of frugality was set aside on occasions like wedding in the family when lavish expenses were incurred leading to occasional

economic disaster.¹¹⁸ Commenting on their frugal attitude towards dress Tavernier remarks that they went about generally dressed in only 'a band round their waist and a miserable handkerchief' on the head. He cautions:

In this Country one pays no attention to dress, and a person who has but a miserable ell of calico about his loins may sometimes have a good parcel of diamonds concealed...¹¹⁹

Another characteristic feature of a *baniya* was the secretiveness about his hoarded wealth. Banarasidas rationalizes this attitude as follows:

There are nine un-utterables concerning one self: age, wealth, affairs of the household, deeds of charity, glory, infamy, measures taken for health, escapades and plans for future action. A man's wealth, then, is not something that he should talk about, and I, too, shall remain silent on the subject.¹²⁰

Secrecy is the key to success in trade and commerce. It was a popular belief that the *baniyas* were perfect in maintaining trade secrets.¹²¹ Thus, Roques:

Their mutual understanding is so great and their union so close that all your money will not be able to corrupt one in order to know what the other does.¹²²

They were so secretive about their wealth that even other *baniyas* would not know of it.¹²³ That is why it is difficult to compute the exact quantum of wealth acquired by a *baniya*: we only know that some of them were called *karorpati*, *laksheshwri* and *dhaneshwri*.¹²⁴ However, we do come across some estimates of wealth in the case of the great *sâhs* and merchants. For example, the "estate" of Virji Vora of Surat was said to be worth 8 million rupees in the 1660's.¹²⁵ But this was the estimate of the Europeans: Virji Vora never chose to disclose his wealth himself. The answer to this trait might be found in the State's attitude towards this class:

There is another thing above all the rest an unpardonable Offence; for a Banyan or Rich Broker to grow Wealthy without protection of some Great person; for it is so mighty a Disquiet to the Governor, that he can never be at ease till he has seen the bottom of this Mischief; which is always cured by Transfushion of Treasure out of the Banyans into the Governors Coffers: Which makes them become humble Suitors for the Umbrage of any of Quality, to screen them from this Violence.¹²⁶

Thus we have the evidence of *Ardhakathanak* that Nawab Qilich Khan, the governor of Jaunpur in 1595 demanded such huge amounts from the merchants and jewellers of that town that they were constrained to close shop and flee from the area.¹²⁷ It was only after the recall of this

governor that the merchants could return to Jaunpur and resume business.¹²⁸

Their secretiveness was not confined only to their wealth. It appears that even in their business transactions they resorted to a 'silent' method to hide their actual income accrued from it:

I have to record a rather singular and curious account of the manner in which the Indians, whether they are idolators or Musalmans, make their sales of all kinds of commodities. All passes in complete silence and without anyone speaking. The seller and the buyer sit facing one another, like two tailors, and one of the two opening his waistband, the seller takes the right hand of the buyer and covers his own with his waistband, under which in the presence of many other merchants, who occupy themselves sometimes in the same manner, the sale is completed secretly without anyone having cognizance of it. For the seller and buyer talk neither by means of their lips or their eyes, but only by the hand, which they manage to do in the following manner: When the seller takes the whole hand of the buyer that means 1,000, and as many times as he presses it so many thousands of pagodas or rupees, according to the coin which may be in question. When he takes only five fingers that means 500, and when he takes only one it means 100. By taking only the half up to the middle joint, 50 is meant, and the end of the finger up to the first signifies 10....¹²⁹

Both the Hindu and Jain merchants are reported to have deep regard for their religious beliefs and rituals.¹³⁰

...The are devout Proselytes in the Worship of the Country, and tenacious of their Rites and Customs; strict Observers of Omens, so that in travelling ten miles they shall sometimes double the Ground, to avoid encountering a *Caphala* [caravan] of Asses, or to take the Hand of a Flock of Goats or Cows grazing: *In the rains they will not ride in a Coach for fear they should kill the Insects generated in the Cart-Ruts, or Stinking Puddles*: So foolishly superstitious are they and precise in Matters of Religion; in cases of Trade they are not so hide-bound, giving their Consciences more Scope, and boggle at no Villany for an Emolument.¹³¹

In spite of what Fryer says, we find Kharagsen, the father of Banarsi Das, hiring a horse carriage (*ek turgam ek rath*) in 1576 to transport his family and possessions to Jaunpur.¹³² He does not appear to have had any compunction in trampling over insects under the cart-rut of his carriage.

The *baniyas* as to be expected were strict vegetarian in their food habits:

The *baniyas* are a certain class of Hindus who eat neither flesh nor

fish, and only consume grain, vegetables, milk, and great deal of butter.¹³³

Some information is also available on their mode of sitting even while partaking their food. Van W. Geleynssen de Jongh, a Dutch factor thus mentions:

Their (the *baniyas*) manner in sitting in any place (in their house) is mostly on ground on which they usually lay a sheet (carpet or other cloth) which generally is a white sheet or of woollen cloth. This is the usual method used by (even) the substantial merchants.¹³⁴

The Muslim merchants however used 'chairs' (*stoelen*) to sit in their verandahs. In their rooms however they would use the ground covered with white sheets like their non-Muslim brethren. On their tables they would however have dishes prepared from *halal* meat. Intoxicants were also prohibited from their tables.¹³⁵

According to Manucci the *baniyas* were the 'most superstitious' amongst all the Hindus as far as the devotion to the cows were concerned:

They are very desirous of owning a cow, from the worship that they pay to this animal. They are so devoted to the cow, in whom rests their entire hope of salvation, that in the agony of death they take hold of a cow's tail and die with it in their hands. By this act they imagine they are absolved from all their sins; they think that the cow carries them aloft into the sky without touching those flames of fire that they have merited for their sinful deeds.....when purchase the animals urinates on the dying man while holding its tail in his hand, far from trying to keep him out of the way, they say that he has been made holy, and perform great rejoicings at great expense in gratitude for such a favour.¹³⁶

Manucci also comments on their great veneration of the *gangajal* (the water of the river Ganges) which, he says, they carried to great distances. They would also trudge from far off places to the banks of Ganges to take the holy dip which would help them 'attain redemption and become delivered from ... sins'.¹³⁷

The image that the *baniyas* tried to build up was that they were staunch believers in non-violence, truth, honesty and philanthropy.¹³⁸ But the perception of the masses was not always favourable. Rumours and stories were in circulation accusing them of violating some of their religious rules.¹³⁹

Again, while they undertook many acts of charity and benevolence,¹⁴⁰ the habitual lust for money or profit forced them to take contradictory steps disregarding human distress in general. The severity of famine in 1692 in Rajasthan they charged five times higher

interest rates than the normal even on secured loans.¹⁴¹

It is also interesting to note that inspite of the strict adherence to their faith; the class could not remain uninfluenced by external practices. Thus we find the Muslim practice of marriage-dower (*mihr*) being followed by Hindu merchants who started giving it to their wives.¹⁴²

A number of documents preserved in the Bibliotheque Nationale, Paris, provide information about the customs of the mercantile classes in Gujarat. A non-Muslim Gujarati wife, for example, appears as entitled for '*mehr*' (dower), that is, the right of a wife to a pre-determined sum (in cash or kind) payable to her by her husband. In one of the documents (dated 16th October 1660) a woman, Phulan, is said to have acquired a share in the ownership of a house from her husband as *mehr*.¹⁴³ Another document (*bainama-cum-hibanama*, dated 11 February 1686) is more explicit when it records that a *banya* (*baqqal*) purchased a residential building at Cambay for Rs. 701/- *Alamgiri*, a handsome amount for 1686, "for the payment of *mehr*" of his wife, and delivered the same to her along with gold and silver jewellery, utensils etc, in satisfaction of her *mehr* claims.¹⁴⁴ Was this *mehr* just a voluntary gift from the husband, or a case of Muslim influence on Gujarati non-Muslim communities? From these documents it further appears that the daughter also received share in the property from their deceased father.¹⁴⁵ As a wife she inherited property from the husband along with his sons and daughters.¹⁴⁶

The *baniyas* cultivated the virtues of "persuasion" and "sweet-tongue" which were quite valuable in their profession. Tavernier writes:

If anyone gets in a rage with them they listen with patience, without replying, and withdraw coldly, not returning to see him for four or five days, when they anticipate his rage will be over.¹⁴⁷

Losing temper was held to be very detrimental to business interest and, therefore, patience acquired the status of a recognized practice among *baniyas*. A Rajasthani source employs the word *saras* (sweet-tongue) as an adjective for the *sâhs*, thereby underscoring the basic element in their behaviour towards customers.¹⁴⁸

The timid nature of members of this class, was obviously owing to their aptitude for caution. Manucci in fact narrates an anecdote to bring out this aspect of their nature. Once when Akbar is said to have invited the 'head of the *baniyas*' and asked him the question regarding which side the stream in the garden was flowing, the *baniya* did not make a direct reply as he was not sure of the import of the question.¹⁴⁹ At another place he records:

They [the *baniyas*] are very careful about the answers they give to questions....according to popular sayings, it is their habit to dissemble even when someone asks them what day it is (they are, however, much more ready to answer if you talk of business). They give a useless answer...¹⁵⁰

Such as were Jains presumably, had an aversion to the taking of life even of insects and Manucci, has a bazar story about it as well.¹⁵¹

As for hours of business, Tavernier informs us that they would proceed to their place of work around 10 to 11 O'clock after they had bathed and dined.¹⁵²

Trade naturally involved travelling. Banarasidas witnessed the members of *Oswal-baniya* sub-caste almost all over north India. He specifically mentions a locality in Fathpur named after one such migrant caste-group.¹⁵³ Similar practice of naming a locality after the new-settlers from Marwar is available in our sources.¹⁵⁴ We are told that the family of Santidas migrated to Ahmedabad from Marwar.¹⁵⁵ Kapur Chand Bhansali, a Marwari, is reported to have settled in Ahmedabad.¹⁵⁶ A large-scale Marwari migration took place during the severe famine of 1694 to Patna where the migrants were welcomed by a big merchant Hiranand Sah, himself a migrant from Marwar.¹⁵⁷ Such migrations probably explain the spread of Marwaris and other *baniyas* over large parts of Northern India and the Deccan.

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66. See the story of Kabir, his wife, and the Baqq'al shopkeeper "in their lane" at Banaras, in *Dabistan-i Mazahib*, 160. Cf. Irfan Habib, "Merchant Communities in Pre-Colonial India", *op.cit.*
67. Bernier, *Travels in the Mogul Empire*, trans. A. Constable, ed. V. A. Smith, London, 1916, pp. 248-9.
68. *Ardhakathanka*, verse 74
69. *Ibid.*, verse 389.
70. *Ibid.*, verses 309 – 310.
71. *Ibid.*, verses 31, 314, 390, 571.
72. Edward Terry, *A Voyage to East India, 1616 – 19*, London, 1777, p.34.
73. Tapan Raychaudhuri, *Cambridge Economic History of India*, I, 341-2. Cf. Niels Steensgaard, *The Asian Trade Revolution of the Seventeenth Century*, Chicago, 1974, 22ff.

74. Pelsaert, *op.cit.*, p.60.
75. Ibid., p.63.
76. Manucci, *op.cit.*, III, p.396.
77. Ibid., III, p.155
78. Ibid., verses 199 - 200.
79. Cf. *Ardhakathanak*, *op.cit.*, pp. 6-7.
80. Tavernier, *op.cit.*, II, reprint, Delhi, 1977, pp.143-144.
81. Indrani Ray, 'Of Trade and Traders in Seventeenth Century India: An Unpublished French Memoir by Georges Roques', in *The Indian Historical Review*, IX, Nos.1-2, New Delhi, 1982-3, p84; Also see Manucci, *op.cit.*, I, pp.152,156.
82. Ovington, *op.cit.*, p.124; For the method by which children of the *baniya* or mercantile castes are trained in mental arithmetic, see Russel, *Tribes & Castes*, *op.cit.*, II, p.128. See also J.H. Grose (*A Voyage to the East Indies*, 1757, p.238): "The Gentoo merchants too use the same method with their children, initiating them, with the first dawn of their reason, into all the mysteries of their trade and contracts, insomuch that it is not uncommon to see boys of ten or twelve years of age so acute and expert that it would not be easy to over-reach them in a bargain".
83. *Ardhakathanak*, *op.cit.*, verses 46-47
84. Ibid., verses 98 - 99
85. Ibid., verse 13.
86. Tavernier, *op.cit.*, II, pp.48-49
87. *Ardhakathanka*, *op.cit.*, verse 134
88. Ibid., verse 136
89. Tavernier, *op.cit.*, I, p.24
90. *Ardhakathanak*, verses 39 - 45.
91. Ibid., verse 67.
92. Ibid., verse 68
93. Ibid., verse 70
94. Ibid., verse 72
95. Ibid., verse 74, 76
96. Ibid., verses 353 - 358.
97. Ibid., verse 356
98. Ibid., verse 363
99. Itimad Ali Khan, *Miratul Haqaiq*, Bodleian Library (Oxford), MS.Fraser (rotograph in Research Library, Department of History, AMU, ff.235(a) - 37 (a))
100. Ibid.
101. Ibid., ff. 423(a) -25(a), 427 (a) - (b).
102. W.Foster, *A supplementary Calender of Documents in the India Office, & c., 1600-1640*, London, 1928, p.68.
103. *EFI*, 1668 - 69, *op.cit.*, p.192.
104. *EFI*, 1651 - 54, p.224

105. *Mirat-i Abmadi*, op.cit., I, pp.410-11; see also 405--6 for more information on Kapur Chand Bhansali, Madan Gopal, and Hari Ram. The *nagarseth*, says the *Mirat*, 406, was "the head of the Hindu community." The Muslim Bohras of Ahmadabad had then a separate *seth*, or head, Mulla 'Abdul 'Aziz. Cf. Irfan Habib, "Merchant communities in Pre-Colonial India", op.cit.
106. Muhnot Nainsi, *Khyat*, ed. B.P. Sakaria, Jodhpur, 1962, vol.II, pp.225-26.
107. See for example, Muhnot Nainsi, *Marwar ra Pargana ri Vigat*, ed. N.S. Bhati, Jodhpur, 1969, Vol.II, p.63. Nainsi records that in case a *mahajan* left the place of his work and went away for any reason and then came back, the state used to take two third of the hoarded grain, while the remaining portion was left for its owner.
108. Yati Jai Chand, *Saiki*, ed Muni Kanti Sagar, Jaipur, n.d., pp.40-46.
109. Ibid.
110. Peter Mundy, *Travels of Peter Mundy in Europe and Asia, 1608-67*, Halduyt Society, London, 1914, vol.II, p.271.
111. Indrani Ray, p.83.
112. Ibid., p.87.
113. Ibid., p.85.
114. There are numerous references which show that the *baniyas* used to borrow money mortgaging their ornaments (both gold and silver) to the moneylenders (see B.L Bbadani, 'Money-Lending and Exchange in the 17th and 18th century Marwar', *Proceedings of the Indian History Congress*, Bhubaneswar, 1977, pp.272- 75; (Also compare *Mata Bahis*, Vyas Lokmani Collection (Microfilm in the Department of History, Aligarh Muslim University, Aligarh).
115. *Ardhakathanak*, p.33.
116. Ovington, p.123.
117. Indrani Ray, p.83.
118. Ibid., p.84.
119. Tavernier, *op.cit.*, II, p.50
120. *Ardhakathanak*, verse 460 - 61.
121. There is a Rajasthani story about a *baniya*, though obscene, which conveys the message that he maintained secrecy even at the cost of his life (cf. *Bandhi Buhari-ri Bot in Rajasthani Batan*, ed Shobhagya Singh Shekhawat, Udaipur, n.d. vol.III, pp.24-S2).
122. Indrani Ray, p.98; also see p.94.
123. Ibid., p.86.
124. Cf. 'Vat Rijak Bina Rajput ri' in *Rajasthani Batan*, ed. Bhawani Shanker Upadhyaya, Udaipur, n.d., vol.II, p.57; *Ajit Vilas*, ed. Shivdutt Dan Barahat, Jodhpur, 1984, p.170; 'Palak Dariyav-ri-bat' in *Parampara*, part 6-7, Jodhpur, n.d., p.203.
125. Thevenot, *The Indian Travels of Thevenot and Careri*, tr. and ed. S.N:Sen, Delhi, 1949, p.22; Also see Irfan Habib, op.cit., p.398.
126. Fryer, *op.cit.*, pp.97 - 98.
127. *Ardhakathanka*, op.cit., verses 110 - 20.
128. Ibid., verse 147
129. Tavernier, *op.cit.*, II, pp.58 - 59; Fryer, *op.cit.*, p.112; Francesco Carletti, *My Voyage*

- Around the World*, tr. From Italian by Herbert Weinstock, London, 1965, pp.205 – 6; *The Voyage of Francois Pyrard of Laval to the East Indies, the Maldives, the Moluccas and Brazil*, tr. & ed. Albert Gray, Haklyut Society, London, n.d., II, p.179.
130. Cf. 'Palak Dariyav-ri-bat', pp.203-4. Also see *Ardhakathanak*, pp.7-10.
131. Fryer, *op.cit.*, p. 193.
132. *Ardhakathanak*, verse 73
133. Manucci, *op.cit.*, I, p.151
134. W. Caland ed. , *Remonstratie van W.Geleynnssen de Jogh*, Gravenhage, 1929, p.67. I am thankful to my friend and colleague Mr.Ishrat Alam for not only providing this information but also giving me his translation of this Dutch source.
135. Ibid. Further according to de Jongh shoes were to be removed by persons entering into these Muslim merchants' houses.
136. Ibid.
137. Ibid., I, pp. 152 -53
138. See Mukund Lath's notes and comments in the *Ardhakathanak*, pp.143-46.
139. Tavernier reproduces a story related to a Jain merchant Santidas, probably not the great well known Santidas Jhaveri. Since he did not have any issue, he made his wife eat fish which was disapproved by his religious beliefs (cf. Tavernier, *op.cit.*, I, pp.61-62). The same kind of story related to other merchants is recorded in a contemporary Rajasthani source. Here, however, instead of the wife, the husband ate fish to have a fifth son from his second wife (See 'Sahukar ri Bat' in *Rajasthani Batan*, III, *op.cit.*, pp.53-67).
140. Hiranand Shah gave generous help to those who migrated to Patna from Rajasthan during the famine of 1694 (cf. Jaichand, *Saiki*, *op.cit.*, pp.51-52). Many Hospitals for animals were opened by the *baniyas* in Ahmadabad, for which see Tavernier, pp.63-64.
141. Jaichand, *Saiki*, p.40.
142. For details see my paper, "Civil Laws and Justice in Mughal Gujarat", *Proceedings of the Indian History Congress*, Mysore, 1993; see also Shireen Moosvi, "Travails of a mercantile community: Aspects of Social Life at the Port of Surat (Early half of the 17th century)", *PIHC*, 52nd Session, Delhi, 1992, pp. 400-9; Jawaid Akhtar, "Merchants and Urban property: A Study of Cambay Documents of the 17th -18th Centuries", *PIHC*, Dharwar, 1988.
143. NAI 2695 / 26.
144. NAI 2695 / 8.
145. NAI 2695 / 33.
146. NAI 2695 / 16.
147. Tavernier, p.149.
148. Cf. Yati Shri Nihal, *Bengal Deshki Gajal*, *op.cit.*, p.48.
149. Manucci, *op.cit.*, I, p.140
150. Ibid., I, p.152
151. Ibid.
152. Tavernier, *op.cit.*, II, p.47
153. *Ardhakathanak*, verses 140 - 41

154. See *Bengal Deshki Gajal*, op.cit., pp.48-50. This is in reference to Zafarabad and a place indentified as 'Karahabad'.
155. Dwijendra Tripathi and M.J. Mehta, 'The Nagarseth of Abmedabad: the History of an Urban Institution in a Gujarat city', *Proceedings of the Indian History Congress*, Hyderabad, 1978, pp.481-96.
156. The ancestors of Kapur Chand had migrated to Abmedabad, but, he retained his house in Marwar (see *Ajit Vilas*, op.cit., p.203).
157. Cf. B.L.Bhadani, "Characteristics and Social Mores of the Banias", *Art and Culture, Felicitation Volume in Honour of Professor S.Nurul Hasan*, ed. A.J.Qaisar & S.P.Verma, Jaipur, 1993, p.52